survive political turbulence and avoid the most damaging outcomes. However, this is a delicate balance: Efforts to bypass populist leaders may be viewed as interference. The success of this strategy depends on the IO's ability to demonstrate tangible benefits to the public while avoiding perceptions of overreach.

Taken together, these options highlight the trade-offs IOs face in responding to populist challenges. Appeasement and sidelining are not binary choices but dimensions along which IOs can vary their engagement across both elites and mass publics. Our framework suggests that the effectiveness and legitimacy of IO responses depend on their ability to calibrate these strategies in a balanced way. Overreliance on any single quadrant, especially dual appeasement or dual sidelining, is likely to generate backlash, co-optation, or withdrawal.

9.2 Which IOs Can Reform? The Role of Institutional Frameworks

We have examined the strategies of appeasement and sidelining that IOs can use to bolster their resilience against populist pressures. However, an IO's capacity to employ these approaches often depends on its existing institutional framework, including governing rules, decision-making procedures, and operational norms. These institutional characteristics can either enable or constrain reform efforts, shaping how effectively IOs can navigate populist challenges. Here, we outline some key limitations inherent in these structures, focusing particularly on how decision-making rules influence an IO's ability to adapt.

One critical determinant of an IO's effectiveness in addressing populist resistance lies in its decision-making rules. These frameworks vary widely across organizations, each offering unique advantages and trade-offs. However, IOs with more agile and adaptable decision-making structures are generally better equipped to counteract hostile actors. Most IOs employ a combination of rules tailored to their mandates and organizational needs, ranging from unanimity requirements to majority voting or executive-driven decisions.

Unanimity-based decision making is a common feature in many IOs, particularly for sensitive issues such as foreign policy or major reforms.